Preston Hill

Ms. McIntosh

SIP 7H

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Mitigating the Margin of Error:

How Error Rates of Pre-Election Polls and Media Misrepresentation Have Impaired Voter Confidence and Turnout, and How To Fix It

Part of the nature of humans is that we like to make predictions, and more importantly, we like to be right. People try to predict sporting event outcomes, future fortunes, or the best hand in poker. The art of predicting has even worked its way into politics and has been that way for decades. Election season has pundits and pollsters vying to be the best. However, this behavior has resulted in tremendous consequences for the American people. In the last decade, the majority of election predictions have been incorrect. This has caused a huge distrust in not only pollsters and media personalities, but also in the election process itself. From betting on elections to merely deciding if an election is worth voting in, the American voter is being disenfranchised. If this problem is to be rectified, the cause of this error rate must be identified. I posit that the decline in the accuracy of predicting election outcomes over the last decade can be attributed to the developing of an increased error rate in pre-election polling and the skewing of media coverage of polling; however, the accuracy of predicting elections can be corrected using election "fundamentals."

Over the last decade, there has been a consistent decline in the accuracy of pre-election polling on both a national and a state level. In a study produced by Aditya Kotak and Don Moore, pre-election polls are only 60 percent accurate at predicting who will win an election

despite high confidence rates (1). The question of why this is the case can be answered by returning to the very history and execution of polling. According to Viktor Pekar and colleagues, polling has been in the public eye as early as the 1930's when George Gallup founded Gallup Polling (1). Since then, polling has been used to predict thousands of elections. The logistics of polling are far more complicated, however. Richard Baris, the director at Big Data Poll, argues that anyone can ask voters who they intend to vote for in a given election. However, the problem lies in how likely that person or group is to turn out and actually vote relative to the corresponding polling results. According to Mark Blumenthal, this problem is attributable to polling errors within certain demographics by overstating or understating who they actually plan to vote for. (299). In other words, modeling the electorate is key, and pollsters have struggled to complete that task in recent elections. According to Baris, the two demographics that have seen the largest error in what polling said versus what happened when they actually voted are middle-aged, white working-class men without a college degree and Hispanics without a college degree. These sampling errors must be analyzed and identified to create solutions.

There are a few key reasons the polling numbers of these demographics do not produce results corresponding with the election outcome. One reason is these blocks of voters were not surveyed in large enough numbers. This pattern has continued from the 2016 presidential election all the way to the 2022 midterms. The primary example of this is in the 2016 election. American historian Joseph Campbell explains that in the 2016 presidential election, Democratic nominee Hillary Clinton led in all but two polls in Pennsylvania from October until election day, led in all thirty-one polls conducted in Michigan after July, and led in all nineteen polls in Wisconsin after July (194). Clinton went on to lose all three states, which are states with large white working-class populations. Campbell goes on to say "It's often polls in different states will

miss in the same direction if those states are similar demographically (194). In other words, states with similar types of occupation and ethnicity tend to vote correspondingly. According to Kevin Uhrmacher at *The Washington Post*, 700 counties, mainly composed of white working-class people, voted for President Barack Obama in 2008 and 2012 but voted for Republican Donald Trump in 2016 and 2020. This was a largely unexpected outcome according to polls yet occurred in demographically similar places. In addition, among Hispanic voters, Mr. Trump was backed by 32 percent of these voters in 2020, an uptick from 2016, according to an exit poll from *CNN*. Geraldo L. Cadava at *The Atlantic*, confessed, this was perplexing to pollsters who viewed Hispanic voters as a reliable block for the Democratic Party due to strict immigration policies promoted by Trump and the Republican Party. The swings among these demographics were largely unexpected and unable to be modeled by pollsters or media.

Both demographics also showed a specific response bias in a similar fashion. Response bias is defined by Kassiani Nikolopoulou in Scribbr as “a general term used to describe a number of different conditions or factors that cue respondents to provide inaccurate or false answers during surveys or interviews.” Furthermore, he reports “These factors range from the interviewer's perceived social position or appearance to the phrasing of questions in surveys.” Both white working-class and Hispanic voters showed an effect Baris calls the “shy Trump voter” tendency. He further explains that this tendency was caused by a desire to conceal who the surveyed voter desired to vote for in the 2016 election because of the controversiality of Trump’s behavior. Nikolopoulo asserts that the populist ideas of both Barack Obama and Donald Trump attracted a large portion of these voters. However, in the case of Mr. Trump, there was a specific distrust of pollsters displayed in the conducting of polls. The skepticism of both white working-class and Hispanic voters displayed by the “shy Trump voter” tendency has caused a

statistically significant error in polling. Researcher Ramin Skibba insists that due to caller ID for example, people are less likely to answer polls in the first place (339). This is difficult for pollsters because the poll needs around one thousand participants to produce statistically significant results (339). I suspect the polling problem lies deeper in the attitude of voters in America today. Baris claims that due to high levels of polarization and distrust in media from voters without a college degree, such as a majority of both white working-class and Hispanic voters, these voters simply do not answer polls when asked, whether it is over the phone, in person, or by text message. Despite varying methodologies used by pollsters, there have been consistent error rates with white working-class and Hispanic voters that have caused a large disparity in the accuracy of polling regardless of methodology.

Beyond the fundamental problems that lie within the polling response bias represented in various demographics, there is another problem with all types of voters. Baris observes that the ability to proportionally poll undecided voters has reached a new level of difficulty in recent elections. Many would assume that so-called "undecided" voters would be a very low number that would not play into an election outcome. However, Joshua Bon and colleagues contend that there were in fact large numbers of undecided voters in the last three presidential elections (1). In a time of high political polarization, the number of true "undecided" voters leading up to an election has decreased among both the Republican and Democratic parties, leaving most undecideds within Independent voters. Political scientist Christopher Prosser and Jonathan Mellon argue that pollsters often struggle with what to do with people who claim to be undecided in their polls; for example, whether to include them in a poll or to push them to decide when conducting the poll (770). In addition, rather than voting for one of the candidates on the ballot, undecided voters may also choose to simply not vote at all, which narrows the electorate and can

skew polls. Oscar Pocasangre goes further in *New America*, asserting that in the weeks leading up to an election, in races that are very contested, undecideds are often the deciders in that election. He elaborates that in recently contested elections, both on the state and federal levels, the winner of the election has almost always won undecided voters. This tendency is mainly due to many undecided voters who do not choose to vote due to their dissatisfaction with the party in control of the White House. According to Geoffrey Skelley and Nathaniel Rakich, there is a historical pattern that in midterm elections, undecided voters will cast their vote for the opposition party out of power in contested races. Amy Walter at *Cook Political Report* presents however, that in the 2022 midterms, in most contested House and Senate races, undecided voters backed members of the party in power, the Democratic Party. She elaborates that because of this, the so-called Republican "red wave" did not come to fruition as most polls predicted. Pollsters are truly perplexed with this result. This problem with undecided voters is just another sign of the decline of polling accuracy.

On top of the existing problem of predicting how many voters will turn out, there is also a problem of determining who they will vote for. This problem has been represented in every election season since 2012. Skibba explains that in the 2016 presidential election, "It's a big surprise that such a wide variety of polls using such a wide variety of methodologies have all errors fall in the same direction" (339). In other words, most polls were unable to predict the outcome of the 2016 election even with varying polling methods. This error rate could not go unnoticed by pollsters and the American people so the question of why this occurred arose, and many are seeking to rectify these failures.

After the failures of pollsters in the 2016 and 2020 presidential elections, there was a very quick and urgent race to correct the evidently flawed methodologies used to predict these

elections. According to journalist Steven Shepard at *Politico*, after the 2016 election cycle, there was an autopsy of what went wrong among most polls. The polling industry assured the public that the methodologies were corrected after a thorough investigation. However, he continues explaining that even though most pollsters correctly predicted the winner of the 2020 election, the error rate among polls was worse than 2016 and pollsters cannot figure out what went wrong. To attempt to correct this error in the 2022 midterms, pollsters used what Andreas Graefe describes as a weight to polls to correct them in the right direction if a directional error in favor of one party is identified (336). Due to underrepresentation of Republicans in 2020, pollsters tried to correct polls, assuming they were missing a shy Republican slate of voters; however, this turned out not to be the case, and pollsters generally overestimated Republican support across the nation, according to Jim Rutenburg and colleagues at *The New York Times*. This greatly puzzled pollsters and the so-called "fluke" of 2016 was no longer a fluke, which demonstrates clear patterns of problems in the polling industry.

In addition to flawed methodologies, the skewing of media coverage in pre-election polling, political candidates, and campaigns has influenced election outcomes. Besides increased political polarization among voters, Baris claims there has also been an increase in the influence of partisan media coverage of campaigns, which has impacted campaigns he has worked on and polls he has produced. This concept is further described by Keena Lipsitz, the author of *Competitive Elections and the American Voter*, who insists that the amount of media coverage a political campaign receives as well as the type of coverage it receives is dependent on the political bias of the media organization (7). Regardless of the political leanings of media outlets, what is more important is how the public sees media bias. According to a Gallup poll conducted in 2020, "88 percent say the media bear moderate or a great deal of responsibility for political

division in the US" (*American Views 2020* 2). The cause of bias in media coverage, specifically in polls must be identified and corrected to generate voter confidence.

Producing an honest result about finding the truth or analysis of information are themes that are evident throughout the Bible. In Psalm 15:1-2, King David proclaims, "O Lord, who shall sojourn in your tent? Who shall dwell on your holy hill? He who walks blamelessly and does what is right and speaks truth from his heart" (ESV). John Gill analyzes this passage, asserting that speaking truth from the heart and producing what is true in all work is imperative. When it comes to predicting elections, everyone has a bias; however, recognizing bias is important. Sometimes, polls and analyzations do not yield a result that is agreeable or hopeful. Despite this reality, the integrity of honest and transparent information must prevail.

Transparency in reporting has been skewed by modern news media. Media, like many industries, has gone from paper and radio to television and internet. As the internet has become more and more popular, the type of information people have access to is greater than ever but simultaneously limited. This is because according to a study produced at Wellesley College by Anna Kawakami and colleagues, search engines, such as Google, organize their news articles based on filters set by Google (870). In addition, the study shows that 2.6% of news outlets are responsible for two-thirds of the headlines in top stories produced on Google (877). In other words, only a small network of media outlets is able to be viewed when searching on Google. Furthermore, the news publications with the most articles published were *The Hill*, *CNN*, *Fox News*, *Politico*, and *Washington Post* (872). Each of these publications were assigned a particular partisan bias level, and only one source, *The Hill*, was ranked as unbiased (872). Because of these facts, it is clear that that the majority of news coverage is given through partisan lenses, from both left-and right-skewing perspectives. Furthermore, each of these publications listed all

sponsor and conduct pre-election polls each cycle, which is where the other problem has arisen: how media cover, interpret, and communicate polls in relation to the public.

The Bible speaks on the idea of truth and accurate representation as well. Exodus 20:16 declares in the ninth commandment, "You shall not bear false witness against your neighbor." Walter Kaiser Jr. elaborates on the ninth commandment: "[It] calls for the sanctity of truth in all areas of life" (483). Being truthful not only about what election data says, but also what it means is crucial. God commands us to be transparent and honest with one another. Especially when the state of the future leader of our nation is being decided, the stakes for transparent truth are even higher. That burden falls in large part on media transparency.

To accomplish this goal, the way polls are covered by media is just as important as the poll itself, if not more important. Michael S. Lewis-Beck, a political scientist at the University of Iowa, posits in an interview with Mary Stegmaier and Charles Tien, "The media role becomes critical, then, because they are the leading public information source—voters turn to media to see who is winning, and political scientists count on media to reliably report their scientific predictions" (906). Lewis-Beck goes further suggesting, "A danger is that the media, driven by reporting the horse race, forgets—or never learns—the science behind accurate forecasting, which is what we provide" (906). In other words, Lewis-Beck has noticed a lack of care in how media organizations analyze polls, which they produce by simply reading a percentage and giving interpretations of that number as opposed to reading into the crosstabs produced by the poll, which are the demographic statistics that lie within the poll that can provide information on the poll's overall credibility. Kathleen Searles, a professor of political communication at Louisiana State University builds on this idea, asserting there is a much-needed transparency in how polls are measured and reported by media (2). She elaborates on this claiming that the way

polls are covered influences voters' attitudes towards candidates (5). Her most important finding, however, is that in addition to media outlets providing polls in their coverage, not only did the result of the poll influence the viewer, but so did the attitude of the coverage toward the candidates in that poll. What Searles means is that media outlets chose what polls to show and analyze. Because of this, they can choose who to show in the lead and give opinions based on that. Public trust in media has decreased due to polls that are shown in media to be incorrect. According to Baris, the way polls are represented and covered can impact not only how people vote, but also if they chose to vote in the first place. Because of this proposition, it is imperative that the way polls are covered in media is identified and corrected.

The decline in the accuracy of predicting election outcomes, as explained by various experts, is a trend that cannot continue any longer if the United States of America seeks to maintain the trust of voters. Despite the many flaws that exist in the industry of polling and media coverage of elections, James E. Campbell, a political scientist at the University of Buffalo, and Thomas Mann insist there is a path forward to revive the integrity and accuracy of predicting election outcomes with "fundamental" factors that are in play every election season. Furthermore, they elaborate that these indicators are in place months before an election. In addition to Campbell and Mann's claims, Baris lists many fundamental factors, such as the political and social environment of the nation, the approval rating of the candidate, the length of time a party has controlled the government, and special-election results to predict election outcomes. He asserts these factors demonstrate a far more consistent and statistically effective system to predict election outcomes as opposed to traditional horse-race polling methods. Examining these factors will help sow trust in election analysts among the public as well as demonstrate a more broadened view of analyzing elections.

Examining the political environment of the nation is the first key indicator of an election outcome. Because of scenarios that affect the entire nation such as recessions, public health emergencies, or foreign policy failures that oftentimes occur within weeks of an election, these impacts rarely escape the minds of voters. Election polling does not directly account for these environmental factors and the significance applied nationwide. For example, Alice Miranda Ollstein at *Politico* posits that in the 2022 midterms, the American people's reaction to the overturning of the landmark Supreme Court case Roe v. Wade, which upheld abortion rights for half a century, was viewed by analysts as a possible roadblock to a general electoral victory for the Republican party even though a "red wave" was expected on election day. The impact of this precedent set by the Supreme Court is analyzed by Matifadza Hlatshwayo, a director of health in St. Louis, Missouri, and Esther Choo who reveal that in all five states where abortion was on the ballot, abortion rights were protected or expanded (1). Furthermore, beyond the referendums, the result of abortion rights being a top issue for voters was demonstrated in the lack of backlash toward the majority party in power – the Democratic party – in federal House and Senate elections across the nation. Another example of an environmental factor is the COVID-19 pandemic, which had large effects on the 2020 presidential election. Leonardo Baccini, a political scientist at McGill University, and colleagues suggest that the COVID-19 pandemic and its consequences negatively affected President Donald Trump's public approval despite the succeeding economy under his administration months before the election season officially began, accounting for his struggle for reelection (740). The COVID-19 pandemic caused a shift in the electorate, increased voting turnout to record-setting numbers, and marked a turning point in the 2020 election almost a year before election day. By reading the political sentiments of voters due to social earthquakes such as the overturning of Roe v. Wade and the COVID-19 pandemic, a

person can make a very general yet accurate and educated prediction without polls and media even entering the sphere of election analysis.

During an election year in which a political environment shift does not occur, there are concrete factors that can predict an election outcome. Those factors are included in what are called "fundamentals," which are preexisting factors that are outside of polling that display voter satisfaction according to Baris. These fundamentals are what party controls the White House, whether the politician is an incumbent, the candidate's approval rating, and if the candidate has any scandals. According to Alan Abramowitz, the "Time for Change" model has predicted the winner of presidential elections since 1988 by using many of these factors (659). Furthermore, using these factors has shown to work in down ballot races, such as House and Senate elections, as well. Examples of this include Jon Ralston, who used so called "fundamentals" to correctly predict Nevada's 2022 statewide elections despite polls saying otherwise, recorded by Daniel Colbourne in *The Nevada Independent*. In addition, Lakshya Jain, a college student a University of California, used fundamentals such as special elections in Alaska, New York, and Nebraska earlier in 2022 to produce a 97% correct prediction in the 2022 Senate elections and 90% correct prediction in gubernatorial races. As someone who is seeking to further study predicting elections, I used fundamentals in each race I analyzed, and found the method highly successful. I used partisan lean of states, incumbency, approval ratings, and candidate quality, to model the 2022 senate elections.

Fundamentals are a far more beneficial and accurate method of predicting elections compared to polling and media representation. Fundamentals, for one thing, consider big picture factors that are available to everyone, according to Baris. Furthermore, fundamentals do not have error rates the way polls do, as evidenced before. Polls can often sway elections and influence

voter turnout artificially, whereas fundamentals are a result of American's sentiments. Sure, polls play a role; but polls are flawed, have social ramifications, and produce errors. The most important effect, however, is that fundamentals represent the mind of the American voter and the sentiments that drive democracy. By all fronts, using fundamentals is the future of predicting elections.

The failure of election predictors to accurately display the electorate and model election outcomes through pre-election polling has decreased voter's confidence in the industry. However, after dissecting the problems in polling that have shown no signs of improvement, it is clear that polling is doing more harm than good for the American voter. However, confidence can be restored by using fundamentals to predict elections that actually model the mind of the American voter. The Bible calls us to be truthful and intentional in communication, and this is especially important in a functioning democracy. By producing an honest and transparent landscape of information to the American voter with full truth, confidence in not only media but in the election process itself can be rebuilt.

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